

The Crew Plugin: An Overview for Everyone

Generated from useful-claude-add-ons@541b2b70 on 2026-09-22. Verify before trusting.
The high-level guide. No code knowledge needed. A companion technical reference covers the same ground in depth. Written against crew 0.20.11.

In one paragraph. Crew turns an AI coding assistant into a small, disciplined software

team. One member manages, one investigates, one builds, an independent one from a

different AI company reviews, and automatic checks stop anything that fails from being

merged or released. Everything the team learns about a system is written down next to the

code, so nothing depends on one person's memory or one chat window.

1. The Problem

An AI assistant that writes software has four expensive habits when it works alone.

Habit	What it costs	What crew does about it
It marks its own homework.	The same model that wrote a change is the one saying the change is fine.	A reviewer from a different AI company reads every change, looking for defects, before anything merges.
It forgets everything between conversations.	Each session starts from zero. It does not know how the database is laid out or what broke last month.	The team writes a map of the system, kept with the code, and reads it at the start of every session.
It wanders.	Asked to fix one thing, it fixes five, and the one you asked for arrives	One ticket, one job. Anything else it notices is written down as a

Habit	What it costs	What crew does about it
	with strangers attached.	follow-up, not done.
Nothing stops it.	A wrong command against a live system, or a release with a failing test, goes through unless a person is watching.	Automatic gates block the merge or the release. Dangerous commands are refused outright.

2. How It Works

Think of a very small consultancy inside the editor.

- **You write a ticket.** Crew helps turn "can we make this faster" into a bounded piece of work with a definition of done.
- **A manager decides who does what.** The manager reads the state of the project, hands out the work, keeps the overall picture, and never writes the code itself.
- **A builder does that one job** in a private workspace, then hands the change back with a summary.
- **A reviewer from a different AI company** reads the change and reports defects in a fixed format, or says it is clean.
- **Gates run automatically.** If a check fails, the change does not merge and the release does not happen. Nobody has to remember.
- **Everything is written down:** decisions, lessons, hand-over notes, and the map of the system. The next session, or the next person, starts where this one stopped.

3. Who Is on the Team

Crew starts small and grows only when there is evidence it should. A role is added when something has gone wrong that the role would have caught; it is not added because it sounds useful. 54 role definitions ship with crew today: a manager, thirteen roles on the growth ladder, and forty specialists switched on per project.

Member	Job
Manager (PM)	Keeps the picture, assigns work, reports status. Mechanically prevented from writing application code by the role write guard.
Explorer	Answers "where does this live and how does it work". It can read but never change anything.
Builder (developer)	Implements one ticket at a time. Never reviews its own work.
Reviewer	Hostile, independent review of every change, from a different AI company where possible.
Security reviewer	Reads anything touching logins, secrets, databases, uploads or cloud permissions before it merges.
Test writer (smoke-author)	Builds the quick checks a project runs on every change, so the gates have something to stand on.
Planner, analyst, researcher	A second opinion on a design; a survey of what should improve next; answers from outside sources with references.
Database reviewer, documentation writer, browser tester, scribe, cloud architect	Added as a project grows: migration review, documents generated from code, user-interface tests, the record of decisions, and a check on cloud designs before they are built.

Beyond these, forty specialists can be switched on for a particular project: experts in specific languages, cloud platforms, Microsoft products, security testing, compliance, and writing. They are switched on because a project uses that technology, not because the team has grown.

4. What You Can Ask For

28 slash commands ship with crew, each typed as `/crew:<name>`.

You want to...	What crew does
Set up a project	A guided, step-by-step setup you can pause and resume. Then it learns the codebase once and writes down what it found.
Get a piece of work done	Turn the request into a ticket, build it, have it reviewed, and run the gates. One ticket in, one reviewed change out.
Know where things stand	Ask the manager. It reports what is open, what is healthy, what is stale, and what it recommends.
Find out why something is broken	A systematic investigation that proves the cause before anyone proposes a fix.
Decide what to improve next	A survey of real gaps with options and their trade-offs.
Check a design before building it	An independent opinion from someone who has not seen the code.
Release to the next environment	A promotion with the evidence attached, and the change-request paperwork filled in from the ticket.
Handle an emergency	A break-glass path that stands the gates down, investigates in parallel, and records exactly what was skipped.
Keep documents honest	The changelog, the reference manual, diagrams and runbooks are updated from the code, not by hand.
Connect your tools	Jira, ServiceDesk Plus or an Obsidian board for tickets; Teams or Telegram for notifications; AWS and Azure with guardrails.

5. Safety

Some checks must not depend on anyone remembering. Crew wires those into the editor so they run by themselves at fixed moments, whether or not the AI agrees.

- **Before a command runs**, dangerous ones are refused: applying infrastructure changes, force-pushing, bypassing a merge protection, or touching anything you have declared as

production.

- **Before a file is written**, each team member may only write where its job allows. The manager cannot quietly become the builder.
- **At the end of every turn** (the Stop gate), the checks for the files that changed run, and a failure blocks the turn. This is the safety net under every change.
- **Before a merge or a release**, the same checks must be green, and a release without its evidence or its change request is refused.

Two rules govern all of this. A check that can block ships switched off and is turned on deliberately. And when two settings disagree, or a setting cannot be read, the stricter one wins. Nothing ever quietly becomes "off".

6. What Changed Recently

The Stop gate — the safety net at the end of every turn — used to lose all its work when a single check failed: one bad rule threw away the record of every rule that had already passed, so the next turn re-checked everything again. Crew 0.20.11 fixes that: a rule's own passing record is kept even when a sibling rule fails, and only the rule that actually failed is left unrecorded. The same release closes a Git Bash landmine where the gate's own Python fallback could be shadowed by the wrong interpreter, makes the manager re-read the project's real state (not a cached copy) before every piece of work it hands out, and hardens the diagram-rendering script against a bad combination of flags. None of this changes what you type; it changes how much you can trust the gate that already runs on every turn.

7. Getting Started

1. Install crew in Claude Code.
2. In a project, run the guided setup. It asks before it writes anything.
3. Build the quick-check harness when asked. Everything else stands on it.
4. Let crew learn the codebase once.
5. Write a ticket, let the team work it, read the review, merge when the gate is green.

8. Glossary

Term	Meaning
Agent, role, member	A separately-instructed copy of the AI with its own job, tools and memory.
Hook	A check the editor runs by itself at a fixed moment, whether or not the AI wants it to.
Gate	A check that blocks progress when it fails, rather than giving advice.
Guard	A hook that refuses one specific dangerous action.
Ticket	One bounded piece of work with a definition of done.
Code map	The written description of how a system works, kept with the code.
Stop gate	The safety net that runs at the end of every turn.
Reach	Whether a check stays on this machine, touches the network, or touches a server.

Provenance: figures read from the repository at commit 541b2b70 (crew 0.20.11): 28 commands, 54 role definitions, 20 skills. The "what changed recently" section is drawn from CHANGELOG.md's [Unreleased] entry for crew 0.20.11. Not verified: this document's factual counts against any release after 541b2b70.